

Episode 19: Once Upon a Time... (14) *Saint Seiya* Part 1 – Conversation with Kubota-san

Last weekend was such intense summer sunshine that I wondered "Huh? Did the rainy season end?" So I went stargazing in the Okuchichibu mountains with friends from my high school astronomy club. We met at JR Mitaka Station in the evening and drove west on the Chuo Expressway, chasing the sunset.

Getting off at Nirasaki and driving through mountains for an hour. The location we reached had a great open view. About 10 cars of "star people" like us who came to see stars were already there, setting up telescopes as they pleased. We also waited for 2 more families in 2 cars to arrive before starting observation.

Since it was past new moon, there was no worry about moonlight, but high-altitude clouds kept flowing overhead, so unfortunately it didn't become a completely clear sky! Still, the starry sky glimpsed through clear patches was superb - man, I saw the Milky Way after so long! After all, humans are best under big skies! It was a good change of pace.

One friend brought a 20cm telescope and showed us various celestial objects through it - man, this was great! I found myself wanting a telescope for the first time in over 20 years (laughs). So when I got home, I immediately looked around various telescope manufacturer websites online...

Ah, but in my case, I don't have a driver's licence. Maybe that should come first (bitter laugh).

Well then.

The work title I was assigned was *Saint Seiya*. "Hm? *Saint Seiya*?" Actually, I didn't know this work (bitter laugh). Back then (well, even now...) I wasn't reading much "**Weekly Shonen Jump**" (laughs). So hearing the title didn't really ring a bell. Then I got

copies of the original source material and read it, thinking "Ah, so I'm doing this kind of thing."

Original: Kurumada Masami, **Series Director:** Morishita Kozo, **Series Composition:** Koyama Takao, **Character Design:** Araki Shingo **and** Himeno Michi, **Art Design:** Kubota Tadao.

What an incredibly impressive lineup. Honestly, the excitement of being given a TV work and the worry of whether I could do properly among such amazing people (laughs). Most of all, I was excited about working with **Kubota-san** for art design!

Actually, I'm a huge fan of the art in theatrical *Galaxy Express 999* and *Farewell Galaxy Express 999*. When they were released, I was a middle/high school student, and I was very moved by the excellence of those background arts - that's when I first learnt the names **Mukuo Takashi** and **Kubota Tadao** from **Mukuo Studio**. The *Galaxy Express 999* art book published back then is still one of my treasures (laughs). Working with Kubota-san, whom I'd admired since childhood! That alone made me nervous.

Jumping ahead in the story, later during production of theatrical *Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods*, we set many special colouring scenes, so I visited Mukuo Studio in Ogikubo for detailed colour meetings with art. The meeting location was right behind **Mukuo-san** and **Kubota-san's** work desks, and throughout the meeting, Mukuo-san was facing his work desk. When the meeting ended, he smoothly turned his chair toward me saying "Finished? I'm having dinner, so eat with us." We talked about various things then, but man, I was so excited (laughs). I can't remember what we talked about at all. Incidentally, what we had then was delivered curry rice from a soba shop with green peas on top.

So, *Saint Seiya*. As I wrote before, back then all character colour design was colour-directed by art designers. We'd make test-painted colour samples with colours specified by art, check them with producers, directors, character designers, etc., and repaint if there were modifications. Same with *Saint Seiya* - I first test-painted main characters

with colour specifications from Kubota-san. At that character colour decision meeting, I first met **Araki-san** and **Kubota-san**.

I've forgotten which room it was, but we spread all main character colour sample cels on the central table and everyone stood around that table for the meeting. Producer **Hatano-san**, CD **Morishita-san**, character designer **Araki-san**, art **Kubota-san**, production staff **Takeda-san**, plus TV station producers and director **Yamauchi-san** were probably also present. And me.

Now I often speak the most in meetings, but back then I was mostly just nervously watching Hatano-san and Morishita-san talk from the corner of the room.

What was checked then was probably the 5 Saints in regular clothes and Cloth-equipped forms, the 5 individual Cloths, Saori-san, Shaina-san, Marin-san, and Cassius appearing in #1. The Pope, Jabu, Ichi, and other Bronze Saints weren't ready yet, I think.

"Mm. Well, it's probably like this," said Morishita-san after looking through everything. The most important check in this meeting was the **"Saint Cloths (聖衣)"** worn by the characters, but these actually came first from **Bandai's** toy design drawings, and we followed those to create animation colour specifications. So basic colours and colour divisions were mostly decided at that point. After making them into cels, it was fine-tuning based on colour compatibility and balance with the protagonists' skin, hair, eyes, etc.

In the end, I think just Saori-san's hair highlight colour and Hyoga's skin or hair colour needed modification, with the rest being "OK." **Araki-san's** careful, careful examination of each colour sample cel was impressive.

After the meeting, I finally had proper conversation with Kubota-san. Kubota-san spoke in quiet tones:

"Well, basically I'll leave details to you. If you don't understand something, send me copies or call."

"Yes! Please take care of me."

That's all I remember of our conversation (laughs). Man, I was really excited.

Thus began my battle with *Saint Seiya*.

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